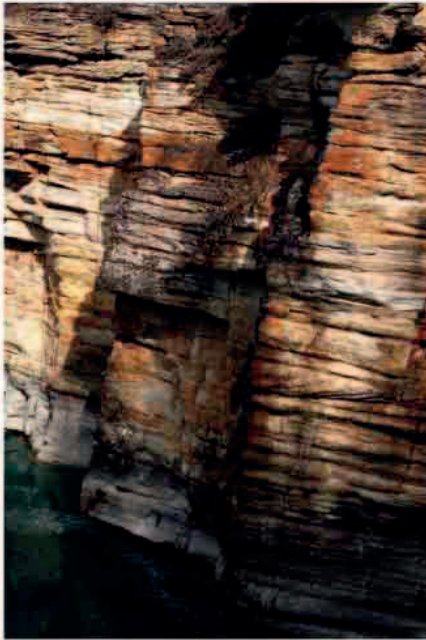


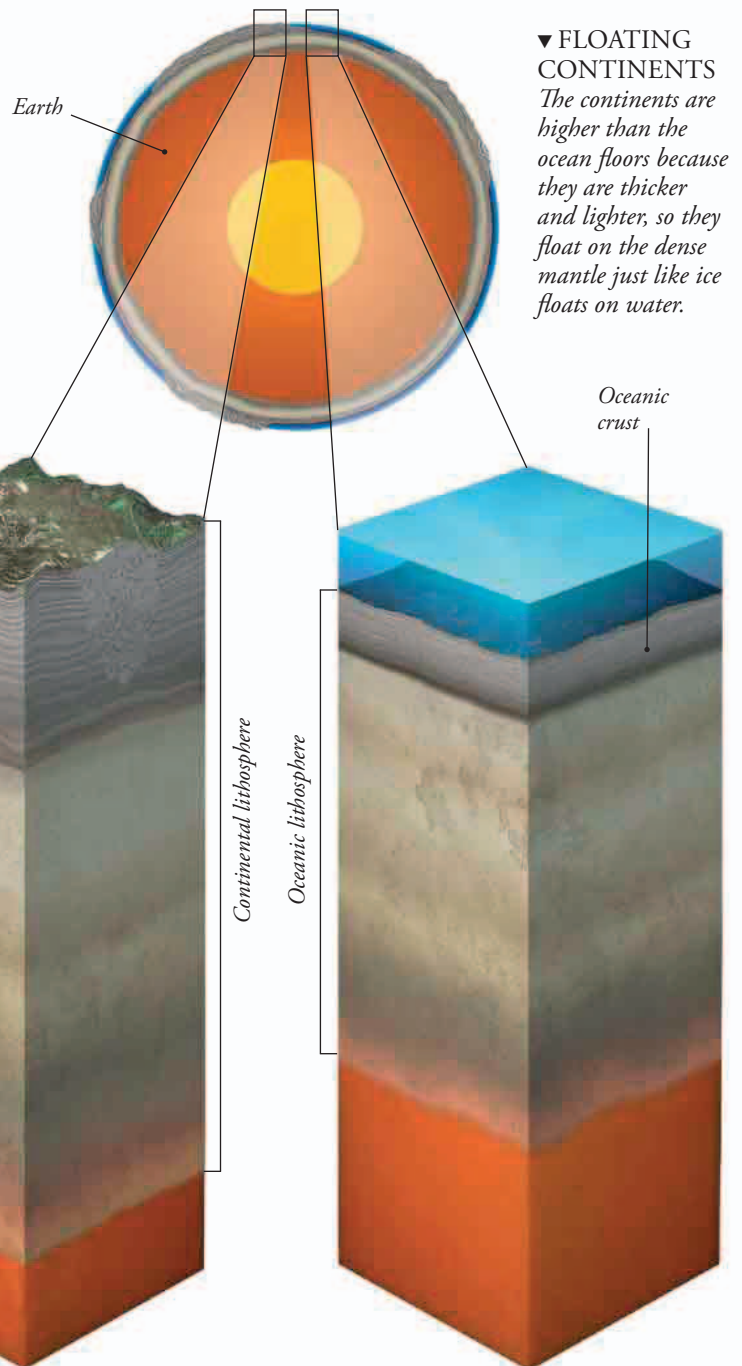
THE BRITTLE SHELL

Both types of crust are bonded to the upper layer of the mantle to form a vast cool shell around the planet called the lithosphere. This lies above a hotter, more fluid layer that is always moving. The movement makes the lithosphere crack, so it is split by rifts and faults, and peppered with volcanoes.



SOFT SKIN

The hard basalts and granites that form the basis of the crust are often covered with softer sedimentary rock made of cemented rock fragments and the compacted remains of living things. On land, these decay to form soils.



DRILLING DOWN

Scientists can investigate the deeper layers of the crust by drilling down into the rock to bring up samples. The Kola Superdeep Borehole project on the Kola Peninsula of Russia penetrated more than 7.5 miles (12 km) below the surface. Special drilling ships, such as this one in the Gulf of Mexico, have drilled boreholes more than 1.2 miles (2 km) deep into the ocean floor.



▲ DEEPWATER DRILLSHIP

The drilling rig mounted on this research ship allows scientists to probe deep below the ocean floor.